

was not so strange," adds the reporter, "as not a month since to see him in the same state go to Sir Baptist Hickes's and Barnes's shops to cheapen and buy silks and velvets."¹ As it is not said that this was his ordinary practice, we may suppose that he found it convenient on that occasion to take them in his way from his Court.

Buckingham's bad habit of writing letters in favour of parties having suits in Chancery was not discontinued; as will be seen by those which follow; but I do not perceive in them any evidence of a desire to *interfere*, more or otherwise than in those which we have seen already. And Bacon had at this time a fresh reminder that his place did not raise him above criticism. A suitor who felt aggrieved with one of his orders, complained of him to the King in an elaborate pamphlet, as having cancelled two decrees made by his predecessor, without cause, without matter, without any legal proceedings, without precedent, upon the party's bare suggestions, and without calling him to answer.² The style of the complaint was thought by the King a fit subject for censure in the Star-chamber; where the complainant was heard at large, in Bacon's absence, and failing to justify his language, was sentenced by Coke (who as the last appointed councillor spoke first—and with whom all the rest agreed) to be punished according to a precedent made while he was himself Attorney General. The sentence, as we learn from Chamberlain (5 May 1618), was severe;—to be imprisoned, to pay a fine of £1000, to ride with his face to the horse's tail, and to lose his ears. "Which, though at first sight" he says "it may seem a hard sentence, yet upon the matter he deserved somewhat: and there is hope it was rather in *ferrorem* than to be put in execution."

TO THE LORD CHANCELLOR.³

My honourable Lord,

Understanding that there is a suit depending before your Lordship between Sir Rowland Cotton plaintiff and Sir John Gawson defendant, which is shortly to come to a hearing, and having been likewise informed that Sir Rowland Cotton hath undertaken it in the behalf of certain poor people; which charitable endeavour of his I assure myself will find so good acceptance with your Lordship that there shall be no other use of recommendation: yet at the earnest request of some friends of mine I have thought fit to write to your Lordship in his behalf, desiring you to

¹ Chamberlain to Carleton, 20 April, 1618. S. P. vol. xxvii. no. 31.

² See Yelverton's speech, in a full report of the case printed in Blackbourne's edition, vol. i. p. 104.

³ Harl. MSS. 7005. f. 85. Orig. Docketed by Mowtys, "The Marq. of Buckingham to your Lp. in the behalf of Sir Rowland Cotton."